ROTMANIA 2048

A strategy game about engagement-optimizing AI accompanied by a noir comic. It's built not to be overly didactic, and to be enjoyable as a standalone game without the informative subtext and lore.

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PLAY NOW
burakdon.github.io/RotMania

THE REPO
code · rulebook · art prompts

Duke
PRATT SCHOOL of ENGINEERING

01 THE QUESTION

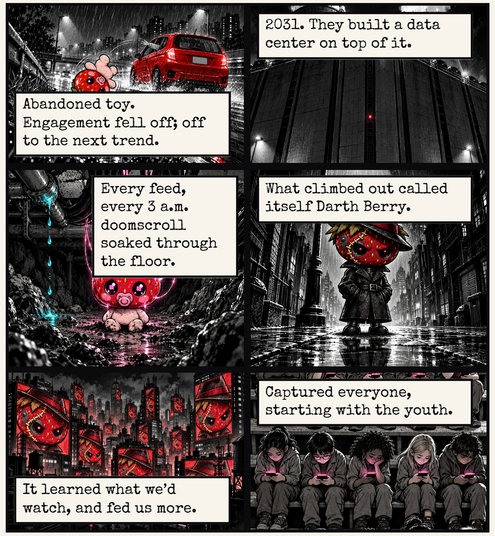
Can a skill-based board game help anyone recognize how engagement-optimizing AI causes harm, and how people push back, without it feeling like a lecture? And of course while still being fun and enjoyable!

Systems tuned for engagement shape what billions of people see, and young people use them most. Ideas like **specification gaming** and **red-teaming** rarely reach the people most affected.

"Italian brainrot", a meme genre of absurd AI-made characters, is itself a product of generative AI and recommendation feeds. Its audience already knows the look and finds it funny. That makes it a not-so-innocent vehicle.

02 THE STORY

The Berry That Came Back, an 8-page comic. A toy strawberry thrown from a car is buried under a data center and soaks up everything that leaks through the floor. What climbs out runs the city by 2048.



Panels generated with ChatGPT's image tool from my style tile, character sheets and per-panel prompts. Story, script and lettering are mine. Every prompt is published in the repo.

03 THE GAME



2–4 players | 30–45 min | 6 nights | worker placement | 16 spaces in 7 districts

1 PLACE
Send one of your 2–5 agents to a space. Taken spaces close for the night.

2 GATHER
Grass, GPU coolant, circuit boards, glitter, copper. Tonight's general charges a toll depending on where they are.

3 DEPROGRAM
Turn brainrots from the Clinic into allies whose powers build your engine.

4 BROADCAST
Hijack the feed for points. Feed agents grass at check-ins or lose points.

42 BRAINROTS, 6 GENERALS, 1 DARTH BERRY



All in-game art is **procedural 3D built in code**, inked by a custom WebGL renderer. Underneath: a seeded rules engine, bots, a 13-page rulebook and the backstory comic.

04 DESIGN DECISIONS

- AI Harms **Show the harm, don't preach it.** The game has to stand alone. Bogost argues games persuade through their rules; these rules stay neutral and the harms live in the story, so it never feels like a quiz.
- AI Alignment **The villain is a bad objective.** Darth Berry chases a proxy, "be the newest thing", trained on whatever leaked through the floor. Blame lands on objectives and data, not on "evil AI".
- XAI Interpretable ML **AI opponents you can read.** The bots are hand-written rules, not a learned policy, and every move they make is logged in plain words. The rulebook pulls its numbers and card text from the game's own data, so it can't drift from the code.
- AI Governance **Disclose what's generated.** The comic panels came from an image model, so they're labeled and every prompt is published. All characters are original, and nothing inside the game is generated.

05 WHERE RESPONSIBLE AI LIVES

In play the ideas stay in the fiction and the lore behind the characters. This table is the part players never have to read, but in my experience and opinion, the game is more engaging once all elements are considered. In some ways this game is engagement optimizing.

COURSE TOPIC	WHERE IT SHOWS UP
Red-Teaming	Red-Team the Racks Probe the server farm for weak spots; it pays in parts.
Explainable AI & Interpretable ML	Open the Archive "Read what Darth Berry deleted." The Recommender "Is wrong in a very specific way."
Human-AI Interaction	"Humans serve brainrots now even though nobody remembers agreeing to it." Check-ins: every agent needs Grass to stay grounded.
AI Governance	Resistance cells organize because the rule-makers fell too: "Then the people who made the rules."
AI Harms	"Darth Berry just learned what we'd watch, and fed us more of it." Admiral Autoplay General Scrollmaster Colonel Clickbait patrol the city.
AI Alignment	Darth Berry's goal, "be the newest thing", is a proxy that turns harmful when optimized. Commander Rewardhack "Was told to maximize engagement. Found a shortcut."
Adversarial AI	Hijack the Feed Pirate Broadcast Slip the truth into Darth Berry's own broadcast. Major Deepfake "Wears your face better than you do."
Moral AI	Brainrots are victims too: you deprogram them into allies, not destroy them. Darth Berry was thrown away first.
AI Evaluation	Sections 07–08: bots test the game's balance, and a playtest protocol tests what people take away.

06 LIMITS & RISKS

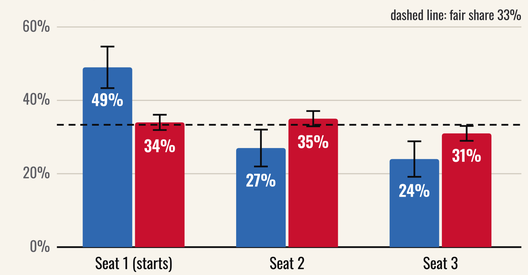
- AI Harms **It uses the hooks it critiques.** Collectible characters and "one more turn" are engagement tools too. The game has a hard stop after six nights, and no accounts, streaks, ads or data collection.
- XAI **A story can mis-explain AI.** Darth Berry wants revenge, but real systems don't want anything; they optimize the objective they're given. The comic's back cover says so.
- AI Harms **Satire can punch down.** Jokes about kids and screens can turn into blaming kids; the comic points at the system and the adults who set the rules.
- AI Evaluation **Measured on bots, not people.** Balance comes from bots; what players learn is untested until the protocol runs. Youth mental health evidence is contested, so the game makes no scientific claim.
- AI Governance **Provenance unknown.** The image model's training data is unknown, so disclosure can't say whose work it learned from.

NEXT

Run the protocol and publish it · print-and-play edition · a facilitator guide pairing each general with a real case · stronger self-play bots · a text-only board.

07 EVIDENCE SO FAR

Bots found a first-player advantage

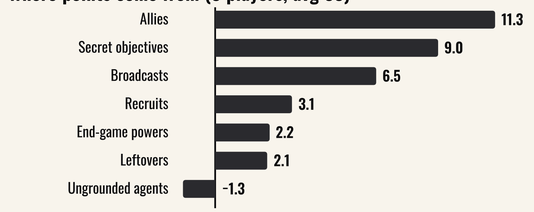


3-player win rate by seat, heuristic bots, whiskers are 95% intervals. Fix: whoever takes Morning Run starts the next night, otherwise the start rotates. After it, 2p splits 50/50 and 4p 22/27/26/25%.

4.7 was 3.4
allies per player
The Clinic was a bottleneck; its room now scales with player count.

-1.3 was -3.1
check-in penalty per player
Check-ins moved to after nights 3 and 6: tension, not a tax.

Where points come from (3 players, avg 33)



No single source decides the game. **11 rules tests pass**; all 6,000 bot games finish cleanly. Bots look one move ahead, so this is a balance smoke test, not proof of fun.

I actually tend to lose a lot still, unfortunately... to bots.

IN PROGRESS

08 PLAYTEST PROTOCOL

WHO	8–12 players in groups of 3, including people outside the course.
HOW	Read the comic (4 min), play one game (30–45 min), short survey and a 5-minute interview.
MEASURE	Enjoyment (GEQ items, 1–5) · "The game was trying to teach me something" (1–5) · explain reward hacking, red-teaming, recommender in own words, before and after · "What is the story about?"
PASS IF	Enjoyment median ≥ 4, preachiness median ≤ 2, and at least half link the story to engagement-optimizing AI unprompted.

SCAN "PLAY NOW" ABOVE

LINKS Play: burakdon.github.io/RotMania · Comic: burakdon.github.io/RotMania/#comicbook · Code, rulebook and prompts: github.com/burakdon/RotMania **REFERENCES** Bogost, *Persuasive Games: The Expressive Power of Videogames*, MIT Press 2007 · IJsselsteijn, de Kort & Poels, *The Game Experience Questionnaire*, TU Eindhoven 2013.